MEMORANDUM

TO: David Kane, Principal, Marshall High School
FROM: Mengchen Li, Consultant
DATE: May 5, 2026
RE: Strategic Recommendations for Leading Marshall High School

Summary of Recommendations
Marshall was founded on such optimism two years ago that the new school would be a success. Unfortunately, the realities have proved otherwise. Violence has forced the school to close three times; achievement has plateaued; and an accreditation review is months away. The visible problems sit on top of deeper ones. Housemasters and department heads have overlapping authority without a clear resolving process for conflicting authority. The culture rewards suppressing conflict until it reaches the boiling point. Additionally, the faculty has largely lost confidence that its leadership will act. The reason these problems have proved so resistant to change has to do with the way schools actually work. Sergiovanni (1990), writing in the transformational leadership tradition, observed that shared norms shape daily behavior in schools far more powerfully than rules or directives, which means that changing Marshall requires changing its culture. Schein (1992) showed how leaders do that in practice, identifying mechanisms through which they embed values in an organization, from how they respond to crises, to who they recruit and promote, to the structures they design. This memo recommends three priorities that draw on those mechanisms. First, use the safety crisis to set the cultural tone. Second, reshape the leadership team so it can carry that shift forward. Third, build a governance structure that makes honest professional dialogue routine, so the new culture can take root.

Priority One: Establish a New Decision-Making Culture Through the Safety Crisis
The safety crisis is the first test of the culture you are trying to build, and it should be addressed in your first two weeks. Before any progress can be made at Marshall, all individuals inside of the building must feel safe. Jones stated this to you in your first week, and between the teacher assaults, the cafeteria incidents, and the strangers in the halls, his case is hard to argue with. But how to secure the building has become its own conflict. Jones strongly advocates for a single controlled access point to the building. Chase and Kubiak are vehemently opposed to that idea as they feel that this would destroy the house identity Marshall was created around. Both positions have merit, and how you handle the disagreement will set the tone for everything that follows.

The safest path forward is a compromise that gives Jones the security he needs without dismantling the house structure that Chase and Kubiak are defending. Specifically, lock all exterior doors during regular school hours, except for the four house entrances and the main entrance to the school, and require everyone visiting the school to sign in at one of the five entry points described above. This setup cuts off where most recent incidents started, and each house still keeps its own front door and its own visible identity. The harder question is how you make the call. Vroom and Jago's 2007 work on situational leadership is useful here, because Marshall fits the case they describe closely: the decision matters, the people enforcing it have to believe in it, and an active conflict is already in the room. Under those exact conditions, they recommend what they call a consultative approach: hear each side properly, then make the call yourself. The process protects legitimacy without giving up your authority over the outcome.

A fair objection is that a compromise may leave neither camp fully satisfied. I would frame it as a first step with a semester-long review, tied to actual incident data and staff feedback, with the option to tighten or loosen from there. More importantly, this first act of leadership signals to the entire faculty that disagreement will be heard, that decisions will be made, and that inaction is no longer the norm. That signal is the cultural foundation on which the next two priorities depend.

Priority Two: Restructure the Leadership Team to Carry the Culture Forward
Within the first month, your attention should turn to the leadership team. Just as the safety decision required calibrating your approach to the situation, the personnel decisions ahead require calibrating your leadership to each person. With three vacancies to fill, and a fourth likely if Jones departs, the people you put in those seats will decide whether Marshall's cultural shift takes hold or stalls. The complication is that each person on the team is at a different level of readiness. Hersey and Blanchard's situational leadership model suggests that effective leaders adjust their style to each person's maturity: directing when individuals lack the skills and confidence to carry out the task, coaching when they are willing but still inexperienced, and supporting when they are capable but not fully committed. Getting this calibration right is what allows a team to sustain cultural change over time.

Wilkins is a capable leader in the wrong role. His academic standards are high, and his handling of last year's scheduling crisis showed real operational skill. On scheduling and academic operations, his knowledge, skill, and willingness all sit at the top of the Hersey and Blanchard scale. Yet A House has the highest absence rate in the building, a dropout rate three times that of any other house, and the weakest discipline. The housemaster role demands daily trust-building and personal credibility, and on those dimensions his maturity is considerably lower. Promoting him to the vacant vice principal position for scheduling and academic operations puts him where he is most mature, and it tells the faculty that Marshall now places people where they can contribute most. The risk is political: Harvey has already threatened to write the accreditation council. The move will need to be handled with care. Framing it publicly as a recognition of Wilkins's real strengths, and meeting with Harvey privately beforehand to reaffirm your commitment to academic rigor, should keep that reaction manageable.

Di Napoli calls for a coaching approach. He is bright, earnest, and in your own estimation the housemaster with the greatest long-term promise. What he lacks is experience. Hersey and Blanchard's framework treats someone who is willing but still developing skill as the case where coaching pays off most, and Di Napoli fits that description closely. The right move is therefore to keep him in his current role and invest in his growth through regular one-on-ones, clear developmental goals, and honest feedback. Doing so takes meaningful time on your part, but a housemaster developed now will pay off for Marshall well beyond this year.

Jones requires a supporting approach, because the issue with him is willingness, not capability. He held the school together through a brutal year, and his disciplinary instincts are an asset Marshall cannot easily replace. He has also been telling colleagues that you will not last the year. Hersey and Blanchard's framework describes this situation as someone who has the skills and capability but is not willing to commit, and the recommended response is to support him and strengthen his commitment. A vice principal working against the new principal makes it impossible to build the kind of aligned team this work requires. The right step is a private

conversation. Acknowledge what Jones did for Marshall last year (the contribution was substantial, and he deserves to hear it), then be frank about what you have heard, and ask him directly whether he is willing to commit to working with your leadership going forward. The risk is that the conversation may not land. If Jones still chooses to leave, filling his role quickly with someone who combines firmness with stronger faculty relationships becomes the next priority.

The community affairs vacancy serves Marshall's culture in a way that no internal reassignment can. One-third of Marshall's students are Hispanic, yet no one on the current administrative team has the cultural or linguistic proximity to do sustained outreach to those families. Khalifa et al. (2016), in their research on culturally responsive school leadership, identify community advocacy as a core practice, the sustained work of building trust and credibility between a school and the families it serves. At Marshall, that work has had no owner. A Latino administrator in this role can begin to anchor that engagement. The practical concern is timing. Given the accreditation timeline, the search should begin within the first month. As for the remaining assistant principal vacancy, it does not involve the same internal complexities and can run through a standard external search alongside the community affairs hire.

Priority Three: Build a Governance Structure That Makes the New Culture Last

Over the first semester, the focus should shift from people to structure. The right team alone will not sustain cultural change without a framework that keeps honest professional dialogue going. The tension between housemasters and department heads has run since Marshall opened, and Parker's attempts to manage it failed because the two groups never had a shared space to work things out together. Mayrowetz (2008), in his analysis of distributed leadership, observed that leadership expertise in a school is spread across many people, and that it is more efficient to have those with relevant expertise actively engaged in the decisions that affect their work. At Marshall, the housemasters know their communities and the department heads know their disciplines. A standing Instructional Leadership Council of all four housemasters and the six department heads, meeting regularly under your chairship, gives both groups a structured role in negotiating curriculum, staffing, and standards. Of course, there is a fair concern that any new committee could become another venue for the same unresolved arguments, which is why the council should operate from the start with a rotating chair and a written decision at the end of each meeting, so that issues actually close rather than recirculate.

The need for this structure is most visible in the Chase-Drobna confrontation, which should be resolved in the first two weeks alongside the safety decision. Without a formal channel for disagreement, grievances at Marshall have built up until they erupt, and Chase's public threat toward Drobna over a curriculum dispute is the clearest example. Chase is the most influential housemaster at Marshall, and he may expect the incident to pass quietly, but a culture of honest dialogue requires holding everyone to the same standard. Greenfield (2004) argued that a principal acting as a moral agent must base decisions on principles that apply equally to all parties regardless of their standing. That means meeting with Chase privately, acknowledging his dedication, and making clear that a public apology is needed. Then a separate conversation with Drobna should assure her the matter is being handled. Once the council is running, it will provide a formal channel for curriculum disagreements so that conflicts like this one have a place to be resolved before they reach the breaking point.

Looking Ahead

Marshall's problems are serious, and Parker's experience is a reminder of how hard this work gets. But the same conditions that make the job hard are also what make it possible to act now. The work ahead is to build a culture that matches the ambition Marshall was founded on. With steady judgment and a clear sequence, Marshall's original promise is still within reach.

References

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